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Expectant

by Paganaidd

Summary

How did Kittrina's pregnancy go? How was Isha brought into the world?

Notes

This story should be read after Chapter 17 of Defiance

Chapter 1: Near Miss

Kittrina and Aster's private apartments
Halfmoon
Ten weeks after Catra's abduction

"Do you want me to call a healer, Highness?"

Kittrina kept the blankets over her head, unable to even face Palu, her maid. The shimmersilk comforter shielded her against the world. "No. It's just morning sickness." Kittrina told her, her voice muffled and thick with exhaustion. "I'll be okay."

At least she hoped it was just morning sickness. It could be the universe taking revenge on her for her arrogance and stupidity. The weight of her choices pressed down on her more heavily than the quilts.

The night she fought Catra before the Queen's door haunted her. Beyond the physical bruises, the loss of the antique fighting staff her grandfather had given her stung the most. That humiliation had cost her two days in the infirmary. Kittrina's grandfather Askar had teased her only gently about it, and assured her that losing to a warrior like Catra was no dishonor.

The look on the Queen's face when Kittrina challenged Catra in an audience that was *broadcast*—the memory burned. Every citizen with a screen had seen her hubris.

What the *fuck* had she been thinking? Aster mentioned the possibility in passing, immediately dismissing it as a bad idea, but Kittrina had found the notion strangely compelling at the time. She could only put it down to pregnancy hormones and wounded pride making her an idiot.

It took the night when Baron Bloodclaw's forces attempted to take the city for her to understand how completely stupid she had

been. She'd heard the stories. While she had crouched in her sitting room with her staff, unable to join the fighting, Catra had been fighting beside Queen Lyra. Then the Spirit Ember had recognized Catra as it would *never* have recognized Kittrina. Everyone had seen the spirit guide creature that haunted the Princess's footsteps.

And, as Catra observed the day of the disastrous audience, Kittrina had painted a huge target on her kitten's head. Unused to physical vulnerability, knowing they were going to come for her child, she'd taken hours to calm down, even with guards outside her door, even after Aster had gotten back.

Her abdomen seized with sudden, sharp cramps. Thin saliva flooded her mouth again. She leaned over the side of the bed, her fingers white-knuckled as she gripped the wooden frame, and puked into the bucket with such force that she swore her intestines were trying to escape her body.

When the spasms finally passed, she lay back on the bed, breathless and shivering with cold sweat. Her skin felt clammy against the sheets, and she feebly pulled up the heavy shimmersilk comforter she'd tossed off

It would have been good if Aster had stayed home. She had not felt right since the night of the coup attempt.

Unfortunately, meeting with Celian was vital. The portal to Eternia would not open again for another three weeks, so he had to go today. She wasn't sure why it couldn't wait three more weeks—but she understood. Halfmoon's business always outweighed her own. She nodded understandingly, masking her dread, and kissed him goodbye.

She listened to the book on her tablet and she must have dozed for a while, slipping into a fitful, dreamless sleep. Voices in the hallway, muffled but urgent, woke her.

“Thank you for coming, milord.” That was Palu’s voice again, strained with worry. Kittrina wondered who she was talking to, fearing it might be a formal messenger she wasn't prepared to see.

“Of course.” It was the smooth voice of Akrash, the sorcerer who had rescued Catra from the Horde. Lyra had named him Royal Sorcerer.

She was not ready to see him again. Not like this. Not weak and sick and pathetic.

A few days ago, he’d come to see her. He sauntered in with an infuriatingly handsome smile and an unexpected offer to help her redeem herself by working with the royal family instead of against them.

He had been embarrassingly understanding and it had been more mercy than she deserved. Aster had made sure to tell her how lucky she was that she had not completely alienated Lyra and burned every bridge they had.

“Master Akrash, she told me not to call a healer, but I don’t feel I’m overstepping. I know what morning sickness looks like.” Palu’s voice dropped to a whisper. “She hasn't held down so much as a teaspoon of water since last night.”

“Princess Kittrina?” The door creaked open, and the blanket was slowly pulled back from her face. Kittrina pried open sticky, heavy eyes, relieved that Akrash had not turned up the lights.

“How are you feeling?” he asked, the pupils of his sapphire blue eyes slitted with concern.

“Fine,” she croaked, words scraping against her dry throat. “Just morning sickness.” She closed her eyes again, wishing the world would stop spinning. “I'm sure it's fine.”

He sighed, but it was Palu who answered. “Your Highness. You are not fine.”

“At the very least, you're seriously dehydrated,” Akrash told her softly. “Let me help? Please?”

She didn't want help. She wanted to be left alone to *die.*

No wonder Aster always accused her of being dramatic.

She would have told Akrash that, only the ache in her belly that she tried not to think about was coming back. The cramps grabbed her, wrapping all the way around to her back, and once again she was leaning over the side of the bed. She had nothing left in her stomach now and brought up only bile.

A warm liquid trickle flowed down her thigh. She could feel a wet spot underneath her.

This was too much. She started to cry, although no tears fell.

“Highness?” Palu asked, “What..?”

“I think I just… pissed myself,” Kittrina whispered, humiliated, grateful that Percival had sent Palu when she had requested a maid to help her.

Unruffled, the stoic older woman flicked her black ears. “Don’t worry, Highness. It happens.” She pulled the cover back. “I'll just… oh. Oh my.” As she moved the covers away Kittrina caught the scent of her own blood.

“What’s happening?”

“You're bleeding,” Akrash told her.

Bleeding?

“But that can be normal, right?” Kittrina's weak voice didn't sound like her.

“It can be. But I *am* concerned by the amount. ” Akrash’s calm voice told her. His cool hand brushed the hair from her eyes. “Let’s get you to the infirmary. Where’s Aster?”

“He’s away,” Kitt whispered, curling up around the pain, holding her belly as though she could protect her kitten that way.

Aster had been so happy when she told him.

“Let's get you more comfortable.” A warm wave passed over her, cleaning the blood and sweat from the sheets. “And I'll do a few scans.”

The cramps came back. Her lower belly seized like she'd been kicked.

It hurt so much.

Once again she vomited, and someone gently pulled her hair out of the way. Another warm gush. The scent of blood.

“I've got some towels.” The maid said briskly.

“Has the baby been moving at all?” Akrash asked.

“I’m not sure. I thought I felt a fluttering the last few days but…”

“May I examine you? I just want to feel your belly. We can do anything internal when we get to the infirmary.”

Kittrina nodded and rolled onto her back.

He pressed against both sides of the slight bump. It felt hard.

“All right. Can you sit up a little?"

Palu and Akrash gently pulled her up.

Moving was a terrible idea and she heaved again. Akrash held her hair and patted her back. She looked down at herself. “That…

That’s a lot of blood.”

A red stain halfway down the inside of her thighs and the terrible pain wrapped around her back again.

“Aaah!” The pain forced an involuntary shriek from her lips. She leaned against Akrash, shaking and sick. He wrapped his strong arm around her, not letting her fall.

A sudden flurry. The door banged open. Far too many people in the room, all dressed in infirmary green. They brought in a stretcher on wheels.

“Please don't let my baby die.” She wrapped her hand around Akrash’s wrist, meeting his soft blue eyes.

“I'll do the best I can.” He kept his arm around her and took her hand to help her stand and move over to the cot.

When she was settled, he didn’t let go of her hand. He held it even as he gave instructions to one of the attendants to call ahead and let Lenio know.

"Please don't let my baby die." The terror on Kittrina's face wrung Akrash's heart.

Given the amount of blood and what his cursory exam showed, his priority would be to first save Princess Kittrina's life. Second, to save her future fertility. And a distant third, to save this pregnancy.

In Mystacor, he learned Etherian pregnancies differed from magicat, but the complications didn’t.

"I'll do the best I can." He helped her to the gurney. When he'd seen how much blood Kittrina had lost, Palu had called the infirmary. They sent two of the midwives trained in surgical intervention and two apprentices.

"Tell Dr. Lenio that Princess Kittrina has a threatened spontaneous abortion," he directed one of the apprentices, very quietly. "Possible placental abruption."

Her eyes widened as she nodded, sending the message.

Akrash was glad Kittrina gave no indication she understood the medical terminology. He kept hold of her cold hand, wishing he dared use a teleport spell, but that was risky with a pregnant woman to begin with.

They paused in the foyer where the midwife had room to start an I.V.

Kittrina did not flinch, not even a moan.

Quiet patients were scary patients. They were the patients that crashed fast.

"Princess Kittrina?" Akrash called softly.

Her eyes fluttered open, glassy, her lips dusky.

"Yes?"

"Can you open your mouth for me?"

Her tongue was dry and her gums pale. Not good.

"Akrash?" The assistant lifted the blanket so that he saw the growing red stain.

Fuck.

“Open that up,” he told the assistant, nodding at the I.V. The Princess needed fluid as fast as possible. “Lie her down.” They adjusted the back of the gurney so she lay flat.

He put his face next to hers. “I'm going to use some magic to stop the bleeding, all right?” He did not have time to explain more than that. “And I'm going to have to do it internally.” He would not have the control he'd need if he tried to do this from the outside.

She nodded her head, eyes desperate and beseeching. “Please. Whatever you need to do.” Her voice far too weak.

Mentally he reached for a ley line, drawing in the copper colored magic as he doffed his top robe, dropping it to the floor, leaving him dressed in scrubs. Ley line secure, he cast a sterile barrier spell on his hands.

One midwife had already cut off her pajamas and thrown a clean drape over her legs. Now she was securing the oxygen set-up.

The other had helped Kittrina position her knees, took the towels that Palu brought and tucked them under Kitrinna’s bottom, following it with a sterile drape.

Akrash thanked the stars for Lenio’s handpicked midwives.

“You'll feel me touching you,” he told her. That was all the warning he had time to give. “I'm so sorry. This may hurt.”

Her muscles were slack as he felt for her cervix, he could see her concentrating on breathing, trying to stay calm. He pressed on her hard belly. Another gush of warm liquid.

A muttered spell allowed Akrash to see in his mind what he was touching. Then another to find the broken places.

There.

Part of the placenta had torn loose from the muscle wall, but the uterus couldn’t clamp down. Kittrina would bleed to death if he

didn't fix it.

Generally the only way to stop the hemorrhage for this was to terminate the pregnancy. It was far too soon for the fetus to be viable.

Blocking everything but his magical senses, he could hear Kittrina's rapid heartbeat as her body tried to compensate. It only pumped blood out of her more quickly.

Slow, his magic told her heart.

He glanced up at Kittrina's face, teeth gritted, not uttering a sound. Palu stood at Kittrina's elbow and the Princess's knuckles were white where she held her maid's hand.

"Can you save it?" Kittrina gasped around the pain.

It tore his heart, that even before its birth this child was so loved, so wanted. All children should be so fortunate.

"I'm going to try to repair the placenta." Despite being an excellent liar, Akrash was always honest with patients. "It may work, but I can't guarantee anything."

Tears started down her face, but she nodded. "I understand."

Akrash centered himself with a long breath and reached for another ley line. A strong thin current of red magic joined the copper. It had an affinity for the mother and child. Akrash didn't know why, but he'd take it. Easily it wrapped around the fetus and the failing placenta. Sustaining the baby while he magically clamped all the arteries where the blood had been gushing from her mother.

The clamps held. No more blood flowed into the space.

Slower, he told her heart. *Sleep,* he told her body. *Be cold. Be still.*

He imagined the cold of that ledge where he once nearly froze. The chill sent her blood to her heart and brain, sinking her into a magical hibernation to buy time.

Now that Kittrina was stable he turned his attention to the baby.

Oh.

The little body was… not right. Weak. Dying.

The blueprints of life in her cells contained an error. The blood vessels had not formed properly in the placenta and they were not forming properly in the child's body. Even if he joined the tissues, they would be weak, both in the placenta and in the fetus. They would tear again.

There were no spells currently taught anywhere on Etheria that would mend that.

No spells *currently* taught.

The Osirian grimoires described how to repair these errors.

Ariel had helped him with this. She could see the tiniest particles of the world, how the magic moved between them. That was why she could create new spells. Together, they confirmed through experiments the Osirian theories. It had been part of what inspired him to translate them, to discover how to change himself.

He brought in more power from the ley lines, and the eager bright red ribbon joined the copper magic he already drew on. Other sorcerers, both in Mystacor and Halfmoon, spoke of commanding magic. He always felt he was in conversation with it. This red magic felt more aware than most. An intelligence. Slow, ancient and alien, but an intelligence he could communicate with.

He invited it into himself, as the grimoires described. Not to change him, but to search for the corresponding structures, to

trace the flaw. In his mind, he visualized the twining ladders at the center of his own cells unzipping, to let the magic follow the shapes.

Behind his eyes, the copper magic pulsed and the red magic wound through it, searching, seeking, discovering the structures that would become flesh and blood and bone. He spoke to the magic and it responded as though it approved, seeming *happy* to guide the tiny changes into place.

He sent his own healing energy, supporting the rapid growth. Magic sight revealed ragged edges of blood vessels joining strong and sure. Fibers spinning out into sturdy threads, weaving the body's tissues.

The baby *wiggled,* moving for the first time since he had begun. A good sign. The red magic sustained the child while he looked to the mother.

Young and strong, Kittrina's body, geared up by her pregnancy hormones, only required a nudge and the extra fluid through her I.V. for her bone marrow to create new blood cells.

She would bleed for several days, but it would only from what remained in her uterus that her body could not reabsorb.

Now he told her heart to beat faster and watched the blood move through the repaired arteries, exchanging the oxygen for waste gases with the placenta.

As gently as he could he withdrew both his hand and his power, letting the ley lines go. The red magic caressed the baby before it faded away.

Akrash opened his eyes and cleaned the blood from his hand with a muttered cantrip. "Get some more blankets on her," he said, casting a quick warming spell on the fluid in the I.V. Her body needed a little help to recover from the short cold-sleep.

“She’s looking better,” Palu ventured, still holding Kittrina’s hand.

Akrash nodded, picking up his robe from the floor. “I stopped the bleeding. I think she’ll be all right, but I want to get her on a monitor.”

“So the baby..?” asked the midwife.

“Should be okay. The placenta tore, but it didn’t detach.”

“That was amazing!” one of the apprentices burbled. “I’ve never seen anything like it!”

“I sent her into a cold-sleep.” Akrash smiled at her. “It slows the body down and makes the blood pull back to her brain and organs. Like hypothermia.”

The two midwives nodded, understanding.

“Once I did that, I had time to speed-heal the uterine wall. Then, I encouraged the placental cells to multiply to replace the part that had begun to die.”

He was not going to mention that he’d used an Osirian spell to change the baby’s DNA.

“They teach this spell in Mystacor?” The junior midwife asked. “It would be super useful if we had a couple sorcerers available who knew how to do that.”

“Oh, absolutely. It’s not a difficult spell. Any healer with sorcerer level magic can learn.”

The senior midwife peered at Kittrina, her eyes unfocused as she invoked her magic sight. “Oh, that’s interesting. There’s still a spell working. Red magic.”

“Hmm?” Akrash blinked. “Oh. The baby’s red blood cells needed a

boost," he lied smoothly. "I didn't want her O2 compromised by the cold-sleep. That kind of spell lingers."

Kittrina stirred under the blanket, opening her eyes. "I'm cold," she whispered. Intelligence and then terror flowed into her face, and her free hand jumped to her belly. "The baby?"

A wide grin broke onto Akrash's face. "It was a near thing, but I repaired the problem. She should be fine."

"She's all right?" Kittrina's voice was soft and full of wonder. "Thank you."

Chapter 2: Mother's Day

Chapter Summary

Once again Akrash comes to help Kittrina

Chapter Notes

Happy Mother's Day to all the moms out there. Not just biological moms, but adoptive mom's, found mom's and mother figures.

Enjoy.

Kittrina and Aster's private apartments
Halfmoon castle
Six months after Catra's abduction

"But, Aster… I'm due that week." Kittrina swallowed hard against the lump in her throat.

"I know my love, but I don't have much choice. I can hardly turn Celian down if Her Majesty wants this agreement."

"But surely the Queen…"

Aster sighed and shook his head. "The Queen is not the problem."

No, of course she wasn't. Kittrina had personal experience with how unreasonable Celian was. It would be no good to tell him that Aster needed to be home either. Qadian men did not go to their wives' births.

He patted her hand. "Anyway, you know that you're not likely to go into labor right on your due date. They say first time mothers almost always go over. I'll be back in plenty of time.

Kittrina opened her mouth to tell him that the healers had said she might not go overdue — that after what happened, they were watching her closely — but Aster had already turned back to his tablet.

She rested her hand on top of her baby bump, mentally assuring the kitten that it would be fine. Of course, Papa would be there.

Kittrina and Aster's private apartments
Halfmoon castle
Six months and three weeks after Catra's abduction

She was so tired of this. Tired of being slow and ponderous. Of painful hips and needing to pee every five minutes. If someone told her they needed to drag the baby out through her nose, she would probably have said, "sign me up."

She had another ten days. Aster came home in five days. The little one just needed to wait that long. The portal only opened at intervals and there was not a thing anyone could do to open the portal any sooner than that.

Her back hurt. Well, everything hurt. That wasn't anything new.

Everyone had been telling her to rest, and that was why she was taking a nap in the middle of the afternoon.

She propped up her belly on pillows and put a pillow between her knees and one behind her back. It almost felt like someone was holding her.

She pushed the thought away. She always promised herself she was not going to be one of those clingy wives who couldn't bear to let her husband out of her sight.

Her back hurt so much. If she could just get comfortable. Maybe she should message the midwife?

No. She did that last week and they told her it was false labor. Totally normal.

They also said that anything between ten days before and ten days after her due date was considered full term.

The little one just needed to hold out five more days.

Her little girl.

She was glad that Aster wasn't disappointed.

The new book on her tablet was her current guilty pleasure, a Founding Era romance about arranged marriages and secret imprints. Aster always laughed fondly at her reading preferences, but that was okay, he wasn't here, so she set it to play while she rested.

Another wave of back pain, dull and aching. She shifted around to try to get comfortable again.

The heroine of the book had just discovered she married under false pretenses and her imprinted lover, whom her family rejected as unsuitable, was actually a nobleman.

For a while she drifted in a half doze, on a cloud of pretty fantasy.

A trickle of something warm down the back of her thigh woke her.

Oh, not again.

She'd been peeing when she sneezed. They said it was normal and that as long as she did her pelvic floor exercises it would (probably) go away once the baby was born.

Now she was wetting the bed.

Fine.

Bowing to the inevitable, she levered herself up and stood.

Something *popped.*

Water, clear and smelling of the sea went everywhere, soaking her feet and legs. Gallons of it, it felt like. It ran all over the wooden floor.

"Palu!" she shrieked. What should she do? Surely, all this water could not come from her body. So much, that she imagined it leaking through the ceiling of the floor below. If that happened she did not think she would recover.

The door banged open. "Your Highness?"

Kittrina looked up. "Please." She did not know what she was asking for.

The sturdy woman nodded once and pulled her small tablet from the pocket of her apron. "I'll message the midwife. Your waters are broken."

"But… Aster's not back yet." It felt like a mistake. As if the universe had made a clerical error. Aster was on the other side of the portal and *now* her body had decided to have this baby?

And she stood in a puddle of seawater, afraid to move, while Palu did what Aster should be doing for her.

"Could you… Could you call Akrash too?" she whispered.

"Yes, of course, Your Highness."

Infirmary
Halfmoon castle

Six months and three weeks after Catra's abduction

Akrash's tablet pinged with an urgent message. Kittrina's maid.

"I need to leave," he told the circle of apprentices he was lecturing. "I have a call from a patient I need to take."

He turned on his heel and hurried to Kattrina's apartment where her maid, Palu, let him in.

The midwife was already there. Akrash heard her talking to Kitt and he paused to listen, not wanting to knock on the bedroom door at an inopportune time.

"Your water's broken, Your Highness, but you are not really in labor yet. That's fine, a lot of labors go that way. I imagine you'll start in the next few hours."

"If I don't?"

"If you're not in proper labor by tonight, we'll want to talk about inducing you in the infirmary. But we can cross that cavern when we come to it."

The midwife sounded cheerful and Akrash felt himself relax. He knocked.

"Come in!" Kittrina called.

Akrash strode in, gratified to see Kittrina sitting up on the side of her bed in a robe, looking equal parts worried and excited. The air was heavy with salt and the pheromones of incipient labor.

"Akrash!" Kittrina's smile was like a moon coming from behind a cloud. "Thank you for coming!"

He grinned at her. They had been spending a lot of time together in the last few months, especially since the near miss she had. Aster had been going back and forth to Qadia and he knew she was a little lonely.

“Don’t let me interrupt,” he told the midwife and Kittrina.

“I’d prefer to avoid induction if that’s possible.” Kittrina reminded the midwife.

“Yes, of course,” the midwife agreed. “As long as you’re still feeling good, there are a few things you can do to encourage labor.”

“Yes, that’s what our classes said.”

“I know you didn’t hire a doula. Is your husband on his way?”

Kittrina shifted uncomfortably. “No… ah… he got stuck in Qadia.”

The midwife’s mouth pinched. “Oh?”

“He… didn't realize I could go so soon.” Kittrina hurried to say. “I'm not really due for another week.”

Akrash shook his head internally. Aster had gotten fixated on Kittrina’s actual due date. Non-healers did this. That was why in Mystacor, the midwives emphasised a “birth month.” In Plumaria, the custom dictated expectant parents would have a “babymoon” that lasted from four weeks before the child's due date until the child was twelve weeks old.

Of course in Qadia, births were left to the women. Men at births were considered taboo. That was probably why Kittrina hadn't asked Aster to put off the trip. She may have even been uncomfortable with the idea of her husband being there. Her reluctance to hire a doula seemed similar.

He had known Kittrina just long enough to understand she was intensely private about certain things. It was natural that she might be uncomfortable with the idea of non-medical people attending.

“Since you don't have a doula, I'll call one of the apprentices to come be with you.”

Kittrina's ears tilted back, confirming Akrash’s thought. “Oh, but I don't know any of them…”

It had to be hard for Kittrina not to have her mother or sister here, since that was who she'd have on Qadia.

“It's all right,” he said to both women. “I can clear my schedule for the afternoon.”

The midwife's ears twitched as she looked between them. Then she beamed. “Perfect!.”

“So, it's all right if I walk around to try to get the labor started?” Kittrina asked, almost timidly.

“Oh yes.” She turned to Akrash. “Her water broke about twenty minutes ago. I'll check in with you in a couple of hours. Message me if her contractions are established before then.”

“Of course.” He inclined his head to her and then turned to Kittrina. “Well, if we need to have you walking, where would you like to walk?”

“Where?” Kittrina’s head tilted. “I assumed I'd be confined to my apartment.”

“Oh, no, Your Highness.” The midwife told her kindly. “All I ask is that you stay within the castle.” She smiled again. “Try and eat something light and stay hydrated. I’ll leave you in Master Akrash's capable hands.

Kittrina had not expected the first few hours of her labor to be *fun*.

Akrash slipped out while the midwife helped her dress in loose layers. In their classes, the midwives talked about how walking helped the baby descend and would encourage labor, but Kittrina had envisioned the walking to be pacing around their sitting room at best.

At the door, Akrash teasingly offered her his arm like the gallant in her romance, making her giggle.

“I took the liberty of ordering you some meat rolls and sparkling water,” he told her, gesturing to a small tray prepared by the staff. “You won't want to eat once labor gets well established, but right now you should try to eat something to keep your strength up.”

The meat rolls were her favorite, savory and warm, although Akrash probably didn’t know that. They were just something easy to eat while she walked, providing a welcome distraction from the intermittent tightening in her back.

“Tell me about your life on Etheria?” Kittrina asked as she waddled along beside him through the less traveled corridors of the castle. She was nervous and excited and scared. She couldn’t find anything to settle her mind on, and the silence of the halls made her feel Aster's absence even more keenly.

Akrash grinned and told her about Mystacor; a city of spires and sorcery floating invisible among the clouds. He described the hot mineral springs and the magical silverfins who lived in the canals and fountains. He spoke of his adoptive mother, who was called the Mad Duchess by the Horde and even, occasionally, by her allies for her eccentric brilliance and unpredictable tactics.

He told her about his adopted sister Ariel and how she was just as mad, always chasing some magical theory or getting into trouble. He painted vivid pictures of his travels across the planet, telling her about the sparkling crystal architecture of Bright Moon, the lush, oversized blossoms of Plumaria, and the vast, shimmering coast of Salineas. As he talked, the world beyond the castle walls

seemed to open up, and for a little while, Kittrina forgot to be afraid of what was coming next.

They had been whiled away the afternoon like this, but eventually Kittrina felt a hard tightening of her belly.

"OW." The pain in her back reasserted itself but this time it didn't fade. Rather it reached around to her lower belly and squeezed like a hard cramp. "Owowow," she gasped, swaying unconsciously as the contraction passed over her.

"Okay, you're okay," Akrash intoned softly, taking her hand.

After a moment it slacked off. "Oh. That hurt."

Akrash smiled encouragingly. "That was a whole thirty seconds! You're doing it!"

"It-it's started?" asked Kittrina, anxiously.

"Seems so. Come on, we should get back and call the midwife.

They stopped twice more on the way back to let a contraction pass over her. The third time, it seemed to last much longer.

A low moan burst from her throat and she scrabbled at the wall with one hand to hold herself up.

"It's okay, I've got you." Akrash slid his arm around her waist and she put both of hers around her neck. He swayed with her as she shifted from foot to foot.

And then it passed.

"It's such a *different* pain." Kittrina said softly. Their foreheads were pressed together. "It hurts so much and then it's gone so completely."

Akrash nodded. "I'm told there is little that compares."

When her pains eased, they started again. “I sent the midwife a message.” Akrash told her. “She’ll meet us there.”

“Thank you.” For some reason, Kittrina started crying, a little snuffling sob. Why was she crying?

“Hey, you’re okay. I’m here.” Akrash put his arm around her again. “What’s going on?”

“I don’t… I don’t know.” Kittrina snuffled and felt her shoulders shake. “I feel so… strange.”

Akrash squeezed her waist reassuringly. “Labor hormones are really intense.”

“Oh. Okay.” But Kittrina couldn’t stop. Tears leaked down her face.

Akrash stopped, and turned to face her. “Kittrina?”

“It’s nothing… I just… I thought Aster would be here.”

“I'm so sorry.” Akrash reached into the pocket of his robes, drew out a lace handkerchief and handed it to her. “That sounds disappointing.” he rubbed her back while she mopped her face.

“I guess… I mean, I never thought of him being here and then they said he could be and now he’s going to be so sad he missed it.” She smiled wanly. “I’m sorry, I must sound stupid.”

“No. It’s all right. Births never go exactly the way you envision.” Akrash told her gently. “You’re allowed to be sad. So is Aster.” He rubbed her back. “I know the most important thing to *him* will be that you and the baby are taken care of.”

Kittrina’s shoulders relaxed. Of course he would. Akrash knew exactly the right things to say. On Qadia, Aster would not even have been involved at all, but he came to every midwife appointment with her when he was home. He loved her. That was the most important thing.

The midwife and one of her apprentices waited inside Kittrina's sitting room with several bags of equipment.

"Your Highness?" Palu came from the bedroom. "I've set up the bed for you."

"Thank you." Kittrina smiled, intending to say more but the pain began again. It started in her back and now, instead of restricting itself to her lower abdomen, it encompassed her whole belly.

Involuntarily Kittrina shrieked and bent over.

Akrash was there.

He crouched in front of her and put her hands on his shoulders, then he straightened. "You're okay. You're okay. I've got you." He murmured, swaying with her.

Oh. That's why he was doing it. The swaying helped. *A lot.*

"That. That's better," she gasped as the contraction eased off. She felt another gush of fluid into the pad she wore.

She looked up into Akrash's blue eyes and he grinned down at her. "In Plumeria, they have a whole tradition of 'dancing the baby into the world'. They have this dance form with emphasis on hip motions and the mothers do say it helps."

The apprentice spoke up. "They do that in cave culture too. They call the dance form 'belly dancing'."

"*Does* it help?" Kittrina asked, fascinated.

The midwife laughed a little. "Oh, yes. The muscle movements help the baby descend and relax the pelvic floor."

"That's beautiful." Kittrina marveled at the idea, her ears twitching.

The apprentice glanced at the midwife and then ventured, “I can show you some of the movements right now. They might help. I can even find some music if you’d like that. It helps to find a rhythm.”

For the next few hours, every time Kittrina had a contraction, she followed the apprentice's instructions. She focused on the fluid motions, swaying her hips in wide circles and rocking her pelvis back and forth to create space for her daughter. Akrash, the midwife, and her apprentice took turns swaying with her, anchoring her and holding her. Every few contractions, they encouraged her to drink something to stay hydrated.

The soft music and rhythmic swaying provided a soothing backdrop, but the contractions were coming harder and faster now, demanding Kittrina's full concentration.

Her lower back blazed with agony. She tried not to cry out, she didn’t want them to think she was weak, but tears came down her cheeks and she could not stifle the moans.

“Kittrina?” Akrash held her up, but she kept wanting to bend over. Her back hurt so much. “Why don’t you try your hands and knees now?”

It seemed like a good idea. Maybe it would get the baby to move. She sank down in front of the couch onto the pillow he put there and something warm pressed into the back of her hips.

Oh. That helped.

Through the next few contractions, she labored on hands and knees. Wherever she was, Akrash’s sure hands found the exact places to press with the hotpack.

It crossed her mind that whoever married Akrash would be a very lucky woman indeed.

“Something’s changed.” Kittrina couldn’t say *what* but something

had. Her back stopped hurting so much. Now the pain spiked through her hips.

"All right." the midwife said, her voice calm and professional."I'd like to do a quick internal exam, if that's all right with you?" Up until now, she had been listening to the baby's heart and taking Kittrina's blood pressure without doing anything internal. "We should probably get ready for the next stage."

"Would you like me to come?" Akrash asked softly. "Or I can stay out here, if you prefer."

Kittrina's fingers twined around his. "Please come. I want someone to hold my hand," she whispered.

Kittrina was so strong. Lithe and graceful even full term, she swayed and circled her hips through each contraction. As the evening wore on and the contractions became more intense, the labor settled into her back. He saw the agony on her face, in the involuntary cries that escaped her throat.

The way the baby lay, the back of her head was pressing into Kittrina's sacrum. Bone against bone. He helped her to sink to her hands and knees since it often helped the baby turn. The apprentice handed him a hotpack and he pressed it into her sacrum.

When the midwife said she wanted to examine her, he drew Kittrina to her feet once the contraction passed.

Her legs shook as she stood and the midwife and her apprentice exchanged a quick smile. The shaking indicated it was getting close to time to push.

Palu had set up the bed with absorbent pads to protect the sheets and the midwife's equipment in the corner.

"Where do you want me?" Akrash asked Kittrina.

She blinked at him and he smiled, realizing his mistake. "I mean, do you want me to sit next to you on the bed or would you prefer me to get a chair?" Kittrina's attention was so focused on her labor that the question must have seemed a non-sequitur.

"Sit with me?" she gasped.

"Why don't you sit behind her so she can lean against you?" the apprentice offered.

Kittrina nodded. "That would be good."

He had long since doffed his robes and was dressed in his shirt sleeves and trousers. He sat down with his back to the headboard.

The apprentice helped her take off her underwear and sit on the bed. Kittrina pressed her back against his chest.

The midwife had to wait through a long contraction and Kittrina grabbed both of Akrash's hands, crying out.

"S-sorry," she whispered as it passed.

"Oh, don't apologize." The midwife was donning sterile gloves as she spoke. "Don't try to hold it in. You're doing really well."

Akrash gripped Kittrina's hands as the midwife warned Kittrina of what she was doing.

"Wonderful!" the midwife grinned. "You're fully dilated and the baby is coming down!"

"Really?" Kittrina's fur was damp against her temples. "Really?"

“Really, really,” the midwife assured her.

Akrash wanted to cheer.

Another contraction began and Kittrina clutched at his hands, trying to stifle her pain again.

“You’re doing an amazing job,” he told her. “Go ahead and let yourself moan. It relaxes your pelvic floor. Keep your voice nice and low. Purr if you can.” A rumbling purr rose from his chest as he demonstrated.

Her low purr matched his.

For half an hour, he sat behind her and helped her purr through contractions.

Soon the rhythm changed. The contractions came right on top of each other with no break between. Akrash could feel the way her breath hitched as she involuntarily pushed. She bent her knees and leaned forward and Akrash scooted around so he could see her face. She moaned long and loud.

“Please.” Kittrina rocked back and forth, clutching at Akrash’s hands in time with her words. “Please. It hurts, it hurts.”

“Kittrina?” The midwife grabbed her hand to get her attention. “Round your back and bend your knees when you feel the next contraction. You’re almost ready to push.”

“Fuck,” Kittrina sobbed. “No. I cannot fucking do this. Just cut it out. I can’t do this.” She grabbed Akrash’s wrist, pressing in with her claws. “Can’t you magic it out or something?” Her pupils were slitted and the whites showed all the way around.

“You’re doing it, Kitt,” Akrash assured her.

As the next one came on, she let go of his wrist and buried her claws in the bed. “I can’t.” Kittrina shook her head back and forth.

"I can't. Forget it. I can't do this any more." But she rounded her back and grabbed her knees.

"Okay, you can push when you feel ready."

Akrash put his arm behind her to give her some back support, and his mind went back to the night he had reformed himself. Casta had held him just like this as the magic had worked its way through his body. Near the end he had felt like this. Exhausted, disoriented by pain, unable to control the tremors.

Casta had murmured encouragement, telling him to trust himself, trust his body, trust his magic. "That's right. Just like that. Breathe. Let it happen. Let it happen" He chanted the words Casta had given him all those years ago.

"I can see her head." The midwife said. "Do you want to touch your kitten?"

"I'm *busy*!" Kittrina growled.

"One more push," the midwife encouraged. "That's right. Good, good, good!"

A little body, fur wet and dark, slid into the midwife's hands.

An endless pause. Akrash counted his own heartbeats.

A mewling cry split the silence.

Akrash drew a breath that was more than half sob and tears rolled down his face.

The midwife put the baby on Kittrina's chest and began rubbing the baby's back with a towel.

The kitten kneaded into Kittrina's fur as she cupped the tiny head.

"She's… she's beautiful." Kittrina's eyes shone, her smile soft. She traced her finger down the kitten's nose. "Hello, Ishara," she

breathed.

The midwife looked up at him. “Master Akrash? Would you like to cut her umbilical cord?”

Akrash looked at Kittrina for permission. Her eyes danced as she nodded.

Unaccountably his hand shook as he cut through the cord between the two clamps.

The apprentice quickly wrapped the baby in a warm towel. “Here you go Papa!” She trilled, handing the child to Akrash.

Akrash’s heart stopped and the apprentice’s ears pinned against her head. “I-I mean, Master Akrash.”

Kittrina giggled.

Giggled.

“It’s okay, Akrash is my best friend.” She beamed at him, tired and triumphant. “Ishara meet your Uncle Ak.”

“Hello, Ishara,” Akrash whispered. Smaller than an Etherian baby, her eyes tightly shut, her pink nose sniffing, her mouth tasting the air. In a week or less her eyes would open and she'd be able to totter around on hands and feet.

The kitten kneaded her little needle claws into the blanket and mewled again. Automatically, Akrash put his little finger into her mouth to check her palate. She sucked hard, squeaking indignantly when no milk came.

“Master Akrash? Could you show Cybel how to do a newborn exam?” the midwife's mouth tugged at the corner as she watched Akrash with the baby.

“Of course!” Akrash startled, his ears twitched as though embarrassed.

The midwife petted Kittrina’s knee. “How do you feel?”

Kittrina couldn’t put a word to how she felt as she watched Akrash check Isha, counting fingers and toes. Turning her over to look at and run a hand down her back. His eyes were softer than she'd ever seen them.

“Tired,” she finally settled on. Before she could say more, another contraction hit her. “Wait! I thought…” she couldn't complete the sentence.

And then Akrash was there again with his arm around her shoulder. “I'm here. You're okay. It's the afterbirth.”

“Just one more hard push and we're done,” the midwife told her.

Kittrina bore down and felt something slide from her birth canal.

“Cybel? Come help me clean Her Highness up.”

“Yes, ma'am.”

The apprentice brought Isha to her while Akrash squeezed her shoulders.

Kittrina moved her shift so she could properly position her kitten at her breast.

Light behind her closed eyes.

Cold. Frightened.

Something in her stomach, her chest, a sensation. A muscle contracts. A column of air.

So many smells!

Cold.

Muscles contract again. Ribs lift and drop. A sound.

Sound!

Voices. Higher through the cold. Sharp edged.

Mother's purrs. The scent of life.

Remember this.

Warm. Wrapped. Safe.

Movement.

Taste the air. Draw it in.

A new scent. No milk. A deeper purr. Soft Hands. Deep voice. Not-mother.

Safety.

Remember this.

Movement again.

Mother's fur.

Milk.

Safe. Warm

The high purr in time with the low.

The firm warmth on her back. The scent of safety

Two scents together.

Remember this.

This is the scent of love.

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